

Exercise 23: THE UGLI ORANGE EXERCISE

This Ugli Orange Exercise is a role play that simulates a conflict situation. (Adapted from George Mason University Institute for Conflict Analysis and Resolution Fairfax, Virginia 22030-444)

I. TRAINER INSTRUCTIONS

- a. Have the participants break into groups of two.
- b. Hand out printed role instructions, one each per group.
- c. Say, "I am the owner of the remaining Ugli oranges. After you read about your roles, spend about 6 to 10 minutes meeting with the other firm's representative and decide on a course of action. I am strictly interested in making a profit and will sell my oranges to the highest bidder. Since my country is alien to yours, there is no way either government will assist you in obtaining the oranges from me. Each pair of negotiators can assume that there are no others interested in the oranges.

"When you have reached a decision, pick a spokesperson who will tell me:

- i. What do you plan to do?
 - ii. If you want to buy the oranges, what price will you offer?
 - iii. To whom and how will the oranges be delivered?"
- d. Stop the exercise after about half the groups have reached a solution. In the discussion, pay particular attention to those groups who have not reached agreement. What were the issues there? Were they withholding or disclosing information? What was the trust level?
 - e. Post the following column headings and write information from different groups under them:
 - i. Was there full disclosure? (What information was shared?) (Have a column for the "Jones" role and one for the "Roland" role.)
 - ii. Did you trust each other? (Ask them and infer from their solution.)
 - iii. Would you work with each other again? (How satisfied were you?) (Have a column for "Jones" and a column for "Roland.")
 - iv. How creative (or complex) was the solution? (The solution is often complex or creative when trust is low.)
 - f. Topics for discussion:
 - i. Mutual interaction of disclosure and trust. One can stimulate the other. Trust cycles.
 - ii. Importance of identifying whether goals are compatible before deciding whether competition or cooperation is appropriate. (We often tend to assume competition when it may not be appropriate.)
 - iii. Under mistrust, much creative energy is wasted by dreaming up ingenious strategies to disadvantage the other, or to avoid being disadvantaged.

II. THE ROLES:

a. Role for Roland--Ugli Orange Case

- i. You are Dr. P. W. Roland. You work as a research biologist for a pharmaceutical firm. The firm is under contract with the government to do research on methods to combat enemy uses of biological warfare.
- ii. Recently several World War II experimental nerve gas bombs were moved from the U.S. to a small island just off the U.S. coast in the Pacific. In the process of transporting them two of the bombs developed a leak. The leak is presently controlled but government scientists believe that the gas will permeate the bomb chambers within two weeks. They know of no method of preventing the gas from getting into the atmosphere and spreading to other islands, and very likely to the West Coast as well. If this occurs, it is likely that several thousands of people will incur serious brain damage or die.
- iii. You have developed a synthetic vapor that will neutralize the nerve gas if it is injected into the bomb chamber before the gas leaks out. The vapor is made with a chemical taken from the rind of the Ugli orange, a very rare fruit. Unfortunately, only 4000 of these oranges were produced this season.
- iv. You have been informed, on good evidence, that a Mr. R.H. Cardoza, a fruit exporter in South America, is in possession of 3000 Ugli oranges. The chemicals from the rinds of this number of oranges would be sufficient to neutralize the gas if the serum is developed and injected efficiently. You have been informed that the rinds of these oranges are in good condition.
- v. In addition, you have been informed that Dr. J. W. Jones is also urgently seeking purchase of Ugli oranges and he is aware of Mr. Cardoza's possession of the 3000 available. Dr. Jones works for a firm with which your firm is highly competitive. There is a great deal of industrial espionage in the pharmaceutical industry. Over the years, your firm and Dr. Jones' firm have sued each other for violations of industrial espionage laws and infringement of patent rights several times. Litigation on two suits is still in process.
- vi. The Federal government has asked your firm for assistance. You have been authorized by your firm to approach Mr. Cardoza to purchase the 3000 Ugli oranges. You have been told he will sell them to the highest bidder. Your firm has authorized you to bid as high as \$250,000 to obtain the rind of the oranges.
- vii. Before approaching Mr. Cardoza, you have decided to talk to Dr. Jones to influence him so that he will not prevent you from purchasing the oranges.

b. Role for Jones -- Ugli Orange Case

- i. You are Dr. John W. Jones, a biological research scientist employed by a pharmaceutical firm. You have recently developed a synthetic chemical useful for curing and preventing Rudosen. Rudosen is a disease contracted by pregnant women. If not caught in the first four weeks of pregnancy, the disease causes serious brain, eye, and ear damage to the unborn child. Recently, there has been an outbreak of Rudosen in your state and several thousand women have contracted the disease. You have found, with volunteer victims, that your recently developed synthetic serum cures Rudosen in its early stages. Unfortunately, the serum is made from the juice of the Ugli orange which is a very rare fruit. Only a small quantity (approximately 4000) of these oranges were produced last season. No additional Ugli oranges will be available until next season, which will be too late to cure the present Rudosen victims.
- ii. You've demonstrated that your synthetic serum is in no way harmful to pregnant women. Consequently, there are no side effects. The Food and Drug Administration has approved the production and distribution of the serum as a cure for Rudosen.
- iii. Unfortunately, the present outbreak was unexpected and your firm had not planned on having the compound serum available for six months. Your firm holds the patent on the synthetic serum and it is expected to be a highly profitable product when it is generally available to the public.
- iv. You have recently been informed, on good evidence, that Mr. R.H. Cardoza, a South American fruit exporter, is in possession of 3000 Ugli oranges in good condition. If you could obtain the juice of all 3000 you would be able to both cure the present victims and provide sufficient inoculation for the remaining pregnant women in the state. No other state currently has a Rudosen threat.
- v. You have recently been informed that Dr. P. W. Roland is also urgently seeking Ugli oranges and is also aware of Mr. Cardoza's possession of the 3000 available. Dr. Roland is employed by a competitor. He has been working on biological warfare research for the past several years. There is a great deal of industrial espionage in the pharmaceutical industry. Over the past several years, Dr. Roland's firm and your firm have sued each other for infringement of patent rights and espionage law violations several times.
- vi. You've been authorized by your firm to approach Mr. Cardoza to purchase the 3000 Ugli oranges. You have been told he will sell them to the highest bidder. Your firm has authorized you to bid as high as \$250,000 to obtain the juice of the 3000 available oranges.
- vii. Before approaching Mr. Cardoza, you have decided to talk with Dr. Roland to influence him so that he will not prevent you from purchasing the oranges.

III. USING THE EXERCISE

- a. An important factor in this role play is that one person is seeking the rinds of the oranges and the other person is seeking the juice. Usually the participants will begin the role play perceiving themselves to be in competition over the whole orange. How the role play proceeds depends on how soon (if ever) the participants realize that their needs are not necessarily mutually exclusive. Two factors affecting this are how sophisticated the participants are in understanding problem solving principles, and how much competition is perceived (which you can influence in the way you set the exercise up, what instructions you give). We have often used this exercise simply to illustrate conflict behaviours and to demonstrate what a problem solving solution might be. However, the exercise can also be used as the basis of a much more complex examination of the dynamics of competition and problem solving.
- b. You can vary the way you use this exercise according to the situation and your purpose for using it. One common variation is to have a third participant observe the role play and give feedback and analysis afterwards. Another is to have the roles of Dr. Roland and Dr. Jones played by teams of two or three individuals and required a consensus decision of the group. This variation has the added complexity of forcing participants to agree with the other members of their team as well as competing